

Carbon cycle

50

Every living thing contains carbon. Human beings take in carbon through carbohydrates, fats, and proteins in food, and release it as carbon dioxide gas when breathing out. It is also released from dead matter, sometimes quite soon, sometimes millions of years later in fuels such as oil and coal.

It's in the air

Green plants take in carbon dioxide from the air and use it to make food, converting it into things such as carbohydrates. Animals take in some of the carbon when they eat plants.

Plants take in carbon dioxide from the atmosphere



CARBON DIOXIDE

Animals

Animals, such as these sheep, contribute to the carbon cycle by eating grass, breathing in air, and dropping waste. They take in carbon from the plants they eat, and release it when they breathe out. Their bodies will release more carbon when they die.

Animals eat plants and take in some carbon. They breathe out carbon dioxide.



CARBON

CARBON DIOXIDE RELEASED

An animal's droppings also contribute to the carbon cycle.



In particular circumstances, carbon forms a hard crystal. What is it called?